Kalam was Scientist D, two notches above me the bat, who fluttered around at night and hung upside down during the day.

These virtual designations of the animal kind became famous within the organisation only much later, so in the late 1960s and early 1970s, cats and dogs worked hand in hand with bats. Since we had no blueprint to work on, everything from the explosive bolt I made to the dart at the tip of the sounding rockets was a result of trial and error. Trials we had in abundance, and so were the errors. Some of the trials gave us confidence; a few made us realise how scientifically naïve we were. We laughed at our own comedy of errors, but we learned in the process. So much so that today India is capable of launching satellites into the geosynchronous transfer orbit and send spacecraft to Mars and beyond using rockets of our own.